

3. c. 29 September 1245 to c. 29 September 1246

In 1245/6, a reeve is named for the first time in the heading of the entry for Esher in the Winchester Pipe Rolls, as being responsible – along with the serjeant – for the rendering of the account.²³ This may indicate little more than a formal delineation of the administrative structure of the manor, now that it was officially part of the bishopric estate, but the Esher reeve came to prominence in very particular circumstances. Occasionally, despite the dry, technical language of medieval accounting, it becomes apparent that a local event of some significance has occurred; in this case, a fire had broken out in the oxshed at Esher, had perhaps spread to other buildings, and at least 6 oxen and a horse had been trapped and died in the blaze. Fires, of course, would not have been uncommon in an age when candles provided the only artificial source of light and many buildings were wooden and thatched; but what makes this incident unusual is the enigmatic way in which it is described and accounted for. Two different words were used to describe the incident, '*combustione*' and '*incendium*', the latter most accurately translated not as 'fire' but as 'arson'.²⁴ In addition, not only was the reeve amerced – or fined – 26s. 8d. 'for the burning of the building', but the whole vill was fined 60s. 'for concealment', although the account does not specify what, or perhaps who, had been concealed. If we are to tease out the meaning of these cryptic entries, we also need to explain why, later in the account, the reeve was given ½ quarter of rye 'for his service this year'. Perhaps the recipient, who was presumably the reeve named in the heading of the account, had replaced an earlier reeve, whose services were dispensed with in the aftermath of the fire? Although this incident stands out in the account, it was not the only development of note. More positively, we can begin to perceive the development of the demesne as an agricultural enterprise, not least through the purchase of 7 cows and a cheese press and, from 18 July 1246, the production of cheese.

HRO, 11M59/B1/19, rot 20r.

John, the serjeant, and William, the reeve, render account for £4 3s 11d from rent of assize.

60s from the whole vill for concealment.²⁵

Pleas and perquisites

For amercement of the homage of Esher 22s. For amercement of the reeve for the burning of the building 26s 8d. For a fine of the widow of Robert Nig 6d. For a fine of the widow of John de Assio 2s. Sum of pleas and perquisites 100s 11s 2d.²⁶

²³ There had been a reeve in the preceding months, for the office is mentioned in the body of the 1245 account, although he seems not to have had ultimate responsibility for the charges and discharges listed.

²⁴ Latham, ed., *Revised medieval Latin word-list*, p. 240. See also the *Dictionary of Medieval Latin from British Sources*: www.dmlbs.ox.ac.uk/publications/online.

²⁵ This entry stands decidedly apart from other entries in the MS, even though it was included in the total for the paragraph that follows. The imposition of a fine on the 'whole vill' presumably took place at one of the 'tours', which were effectively leet courts or views of frankpledge.

²⁶ As in the MS: '*Cs xjs ijd*'.

Issue of the manor

For wool sold, namely 186 fleeces for 51s. For 63 cheeses sold 6s 6d, namely three-quarters of 1 wey. For 12 pelts sold 2s. For butter sold 8d. For 1 mare sold 5s 6d. Sum 65s 8d.

Wheat

For $\frac{1}{2}$ quarter of wheat sold 2s.

Sale of rye

At first he sold 10 quarters in parcels, namely a quarter for 3s. Sum 30s.

The same render account for one ploughshare from rent. All in the expenses of the ploughs. Sum 32s.

From the treasurer, by the hand of the lord, 50s at Kingston.

Sum of all receipts £17 2s 9d.

Expenses

In iron and steel bought for the plough 2s. In stipend of a smith for the year 2s, because the smith was out of the manor. In two iron plough shoes bought 5d. In stipend for making a plough 2d. In making a harrow 2d. In shoeing 4 \affers/ for the year 12d.

Purchase of oxen

First they bought 1 ox for 9s. Likewise they bought 2 oxen for 19s. Likewise they bought 1 ox for 7s 6d. In 2 affers bought 17s 6d. Sum 58s 9d.

Cows

In 3 cows bought 22s, with calves. In 4 cows bought, with calves, 32s 10½d. Sum 54s 10½d.

In a small pot and a pitcher bought for the year 6d. In a cloth bought for the dairy 2½d. In a press bought 2½d. Sum 11d.

In one linen sheet for winnowing 14d. In one sack bought 7d. In two sieves bought 2d. ~~Sum 2s 1d.~~ In one spade bought 2d. Sum 2s 1d.

In stipend of one roofer mending buildings 2d. In stipend of an encloser of hedges around woodland²⁷ and meadow, and the *curia* 2s 6d. Sum 2s 8d.

In 5 bushels of beans bought 20d. In 2 bushels of salt bought for the dairy 8d. Sum 2s 4d.

²⁷ The scribe used the word '*nemora*', suggestive of a small grove.

In stipend of two ploughmen 5s 4d, and so little this year because of the arson²⁸ of the oxshed. In stipend of one shepherd for the same time 2s 6d, because of the burning of the building. In stipend of one maidservant of the house for the year 2s. In stipend of one cowherd from Easter [8 April] until the day of St Michael 22d. Sum 11s 8d.

In stipend for the mowing of the meadow, from perquisites, 12d. In stipend for reaping 23 acres, from the perquisites of sowing, namely 4½d per acre. Memorandum: from henceforth it will be measured by the perch. In ale bought for two boonworks for August 12d. From henceforth to be given to fewer men. In herrings bought for five harvest boonworks and for men carrying manure 3s 6d. In the expenses of John the serjeant from St Michael's day in the 30th year until the feast of St Michael in the 31st year 45s 7½d, namely 1½d in a day.²⁹ Sum 57s 9½d.

In expenses of Lord R de Ral and Lord P, steward, who inspected the manor of Esher on the morrow of the Blessed Scholastica [11 February] 12d. In expenses of the aforesaid at Hockday [17 April] 3s 6d. Sum 4s 6d.

Sum of all expenses and payments £9 15s 7d.

In payment to John, the serjeant, for debts owing to him in the preceding account as shown in the roll for that account £4 6s 11d.

Sum of all expenses £14 2s 6d.

In payment to Lord E de Cumb £4 4s, by tally.

Sum of all payments and expenses £18 6s 6d.

And thus 23s 9d is owed to the reeve.

And the same is held to settle all debts of the same account. Afterwards the same reeve was given 18d for ½ quarter of rye. Afterwards 28d for 1 quarter and 1 bushel of barley.

Rye

The same render account for 21 quarters of rye. Of which in seed for 28 acres 7½ quarters. In 4½ harvest boonworks 2 quarters.³⁰ In customary payment for mowing, carrying hay ½ quarter. Paid to the reeve by order of the steward ½ quarter for his service this year. Sold 10 quarters. And thus ½ quarter remains, price 18d.

The same render account for 33 quarters 5 bushels [of barley]. Of which in seed for 14 acres 7½ quarters. In payment of two servants for the year for ploughing 13 quarters, taking 1 quarter for eight weeks. In payment of one shepherd for the year,

²⁸ The phrase used here is '*propter incendium*' rather than '*pro combustione*', which was used elsewhere in the account, not least in the next entry.

²⁹ The dating refers to the regnal years of Henry III.

³⁰ That is, providing bread for those doing harvest boonworks.

taking 1 quarter for nine weeks, sum $5\frac{1}{2}$ quarters 2 bushels. In payment of one maidservant of the house for the year, taking a quarter for 12 weeks, sum 4 quarters 2 bushels; from henceforth not to be given. In payment of one cowherd from Easter [8 April] to the feast of St Michael.³¹ And thus 1 quarter 1 bushel remains, price 28d. And be it known by the whole vill that it is owed thereafter in arrears.

The same render account for 24 quarters 5 bushels [of oats]. Of which in seed for 32 acres 16 quarters. In sustenance for the oxen at sowing time 3 quarters. In sustenance for the affers while they were sowing and harrowing 5 quarters. In fodder for the horses of Lord Ralph de Ral and the steward 5 bushels. And they are quit. Sum 24 quarters 5 bushels.

Stock

Affers

The same render account for 2 affers that remained from the past year and for 2 bought and for 2 received from Farnham. Sum 6. Sold 1. Burned 1. And 4 remain.

Oxen

The same render account for 6 oxen that remained from the past year. And for 4 bought. Sum 10. Of which 6 were burned. And 4 remain.

Bull

The same render account for 1 bull owing from the heriot of Robert Nig. And it remains.

Cows

The same render account for 1 cow that remained from the past year, which was from the heriot of William Billing. And for 1 owing this year from the heriot of John Hacche. And for 7 cows bought since the [last] account and before calving. Sum 9. Of which³² in murrain 1, they said, but as there was no inventory for the hide in the sales it was not allowed to them but owed.³³ They answer for 9 cows.

Calves

The same render account for 9 calves coming from issue of the said cows. Of which in murrain 1, they said, but not allowed to them because they did not answer for the hide in the issue of the manor and so it will be said to have been sold.

³¹ No amount of barley was added.

³² In MS, the scribe began to write '*de quibus*' again, but stopped and crossed it out.

³³ It later became common practice for auditors to charge to the reeve or serjeant the value of such disputed entries as fictional sales '*super compotum*', 'at the audit'; although this wording is not used in the 1245/6 account, the following paragraph on calves suggests that, to some extent, the principle was already in operation.

Wethers

The same render account for 191 wethers that remained from the past year. And for 13 coming from tallage.³⁴ Sum 204. Of which in mowing the meadow 1 by customary payment. In murrain after shearing 9. And 194 remain.

Cheeses

The same render account for 74 cheeses made, which were started on the Wednesday next before the feast of St Margaret [18 July] and finished on the day of St Michael, namely the day of the account. Of which in tithe 5. In expenses to do with mowing the meadows 4. In expenses of harvest boonworks 2. Sold 63. And none remain.

Pigs

The same render account for 3 pigs that remained from the past year and for 15 pigs bought. Sum 18. Of which in the larder there 3. And 15 remain.

Hens

The same render account for 14 hens from rent this year, and all remain.

The same render account for 40 eggs from rent this year. All to the household.

The same render account for 1 goose from rent, and it remains. Order, that from henceforth all sales and items answered for in the issue of the manor.

Bacon

The same render account for 3 bacons from the larder. Of which in harvest expenses 1½ sides. In expenses of Lord R de Ral and the steward for two visits ½ side. For the household 1½ bacons for supervising. And ½ bacon remains.

4. c. 29 September 1247 to c. 29 September 1248

Although a Pipe Roll survives for the bishop of Winchester's estate for the year 1246/7, no account for the manor of Esher was entered onto it. However, an entry in the account for Farnham for that year suggests that significant developments were taking place at Esher, as 40s. was transferred to Gilbert de Sandon 'for the expenses of the house of Esher'.³⁵ The implication that building work was being carried out at the manorial centre is supported and amplified by the long, idiosyncratic, and highly informative account for Esher that survives for 1247/8. Gilbert de Sandon, who we are told was a chaplain at Sandon Priory,³⁶ again received money for 'work on the buildings of the lord of Winchester ... at Esher', and was presumably acting in a supervisory capacity. Meanwhile, details in the account indicate a massive expansion of the manorial centre: work was done on administrative buildings, including a hall, a solar, a treasury, a wardrobe; on a residential 'small chamber'; on service

³⁴ This rare example of the taking of tallage, a manorial exaction at the will of the lord, perhaps relates to the fire and the charge of concealment.

³⁵ HRO, 11M59/B1/20.

³⁶ He was probably the prior or master, who Meekings refers to as 'Giles': Meekings, 'Early history of Sandon Hospital'. In the Winchester Pipe Rolls he is called 'Gilebertus'.